

I MIND MY OWN BUSINESS, I BOTHER NOBODY, AND WHAT DO I GET? TROUBLE

THE BICYCLE THIEF / 1948

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Italian neorealism

DIRECTOR

Vittorio De Sica

WRITER

Cesare Zavattini; Luigi Bartolini (novel)

STARS

Lamberto Maggiorani, Enzo Staiola, Lianella Carell, Vittorio Antonucci

BEFORE

1935 French filmmaker Jean Renoir pioneers a realist style using untrained actors in *Toni*.

1943 Italian filmmaker Luchino Visconti directs *Ossessione*, an early Italian neorealist movie.

AFTER

1959 François Truffaut's gritty drama *The 400 Blows* is shot on location in Paris.

Vittorio De Sica's *The Bicycle Thief* (*Ladri di biciclette*) was made using untrained actors and shot on location on the dusty streets of Rome. It has almost no plot, beyond that of the fruitless search by an ordinary man and his son for a stolen bicycle. The movie's style contrasts sharply with the glossy Hollywood movies of the day, with their sophisticated scripts, lavish sets, and slick acting. Yet the movie packs such an emotional

punch and grips so powerfully from first to last that it is regarded as one of the most important movies of the post-World War II era. It influenced generations of young filmmakers, who see capturing real life, rather than producing a neatly turned plot, as the object of their work.

Cycle of hope

Adapted for the screen by Cesare Zavattini from a novel by Luigi Bartolini, the movie focuses on hard-up father Antonio (Lamberto Maggiorani), who finds a job after a long period without work. To do the job, he needs a bicycle, and must redeem his old bicycle from the pawn shop, Antonio's wife (Lianella Carell) must pawn the family's only sheets. Despite this, husband and wife are overjoyed at the prospect of him earning at last. But while Antonio is up a ladder on his first day at work, sticking posters up around Rome, the bicycle is stolen by a young thief.

Taking his young son Bruno (Enzo Staiola) with him, Antonio embarks on a desperate hunt to recover his bicycle. With the aid

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While Hollywood may sometimes deal with these facts by analogy, the Italians deal with the facts, period.

Arthur Miller

The New York Times, 1950

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